

THE MODERN WORLD

1914–PRESENT

Historical perspectives on events close to the present day are inevitably shifting and uncertain. A historian writing in the mid-20th century might have characterized the modern era as a period of catastrophe, in which all the economic and political gains of liberal civilization had been squandered. However, by the early 21st century it was tempting to see continuity with the pre-1914 world, as a globalized capitalist economy and great technological innovation were combined with rapidly rising population and productivity.

The two world wars

The convulsions of the period from 1914 to 1950 were on an epic scale. Two world wars between them caused the deaths of between 70 and 100 million people, making them by far the most destructive conflicts in history. Both European civilization and science—the twin pillars of the traditional 19th-century idea of “progress”—were tarnished by association with this slaughter. Germany, often considered one of Europe’s most “civilized” countries, descended into dictatorship and genocidal massacre. Science was used to create

weapons of mass destruction, from poison gas to the atom bomb. Even in the interlude of relative peace between the world wars, global capitalism failed to function effectively, the economic misery of the Great Depression driving a retreat from democratic government and free markets.

To revolutionaries inspired by a Marxist vision, these upheavals seemed the death throes of the capitalist order. But the building of alternative “communist” societies, based on the model of a single-party state and a state-controlled economy, proved to be a costly experiment. In Russia, followed by China, communism succeeded in transforming relatively undeveloped countries into major industrial and military powers, but millions died as victims of the state, and citizens were denied fundamental freedoms.

A battle of ideology

World War II was followed by the Cold War confrontation between the “free world,” led by the United States, and the communist bloc. Instead of disarmament, there was a potentially disastrous nuclear arms race. Meanwhile, the main European powers, economically weakened and demoralized, found themselves in no position to sustain